

On a culinary trail through Periamet, one of Chennai's oldest neighbourhoods **P2**

ADHI CHAMPIONS GAANA MUSIC IN HIS NEXT **P4**



Quite the fare (Clockwise from far left) A full elai sapat; orange ice cream; premium table service; rosogulla popsicles; a bowl of soup in lavish crockery; and caterer Madhampatty Rangaraj with his foreign chefs. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

table service and smaller-batch cooking.

Mamatha Caterers, for instance, offers dishes such as gongura spaghetti, adai pancakes, Madras ramen – coconut-milk rasam served with masala vada and sprinkled with vendakka crisps – and Marwari khow suey. “For receptions, it is mostly a 50% fusion buffet menu, and we also offer personalised table service alongside the buffet,” says Sampath.

“Buffets are no longer preferred at weddings, as this eliminates excessive food wastage,” says Sriram. Madhampatty Rangaraj attributes this partly to concerns over food wastage. “As caterers, we have to be careful about food wastage. Avoiding buffets helps eliminate wastage. Moreover, we cook in batches based on footfall,” he says, adding that he has now introduced tetrapack water bottles to avoid excessive plastic usage.

With over a decade of experience in wedding planning, Ramkumar Varsham of Varsham Events says catering to Gen Z couples has made work easier, as they tend to have a clear vision of what they want and are mindful rather than lavish in their spending. Friends make up a larger share of the guest list rather than family, he adds.

For all the experimentation taking place on the wedding menu, tradition has not disappeared from the plate. The muhurtham meal remains firmly rooted in regional culinary traditions, while receptions and other celebrations have become spaces for couples to experiment with personalised dining experiences.

The shift, therefore, is not from traditional to modern, but towards a more curated celebration. For today's couples, food is increasingly part of the entertainment and the experience – something to savour, remember and, inevitably, share.

The changing wedding plate

As guest lists shrink, menus at weddings in Tamil Nadu are moving beyond the traditional feast into global cuisine and Instagram-worthy desserts

Sampath Gupta and Sangeetha Gupta of Mamatha Caterers were recently approached by a family organising a wedding with an unusual request: an authentic South Indian menu representing different southern states across the various wedding events. The result was a culinary journey through the region.

The welcome lunch featured a Kerala sadya, followed by an Andhra-style high tea, a Karnataka-style breakfast, a traditional Tamil Nadu meal and for the reception, a fusion menu comprising regional cuisines from across India and international cuisine.

“Innovation and fusion in food have been trending over the past four or five years. Post-pandemic, people have become more willing to spend extravagantly on weddings, with couples and families investing in every aspect of the celebration,” says Sampath.

For wedding caterers, such requests offer a glimpse into how the wedding feast is evolving – from a largely traditional spread to a more carefully curated experience, where regional cuisines, innovation, and

personalisation increasingly find a place on the menu.

All about customisation TP Rangaraj, popularly known as Madhampatty Rangaraj, who is at the helm of Madhampatty Thangavelu Hospitality, says that from a catering perspective, he has noticed a growing preference among couples for multi-cuisine menus and specific regional cuisines, including Chettinad, Kerala, and Andhra fare, alongside international menu offerings. His most popular dishes include the jackfruit biryani, guava chutney, and the sanguppo idiyappam with violet cabbage stew.

“Families are willing to spend even ₹5,000 to ₹10,000 per head on a wedding meal. We have flown down chefs from France, Italy, Japan, and Thailand to prepare their



authentic cuisine at weddings here,” he says.

Rangaraj also points to a shift in the scale of weddings. “Before the pandemic, families would invite 3,000 to 5,000 guests for a wedding. Over the past five years, the guest list has come down to around 1,000 to 2,000, but the

focus is now on creating memorable moments for them,” he says. Rangaraj adds that 24 years ago, when he entered the industry, it was the parents who decided the wedding menu, but these days, couples are actively involved in the process. “The

trend now is towards concept-oriented menus, thematic buffet counters, and fusion and innovation in the food served,” he says.

One reason for the growing demand for fusion menus and a mix of regional cuisines is the increasing number of inter-cultural marriages, says Siva Subramanian of Kamalambal Catering Services. With families from different culinary traditions coming together, wedding menus are increasingly becoming a way



to represent and accommodate diverse food preferences.

“Instagrammable weddings are trending. Whether it is the venue, with couples opting for beaches and outdoor settings, the decor or the food, there is a growing emphasis on innovation. Even the plating is given attention, because everything is shared on social media,” says Siva.

Social media, in particular, has given caterers a new brief: food has to taste good, but it also has to look good on camera. Resonating with these observations, MS Sriram of VCS Four Brothers Catering says, “dramatic and visually appealing live counters with catchy titles are a must. Dreamy dessert decks, with a range of ice creams, ‘Pulp at Your Point’ for fresh juices, street food counters, 90s-kids counters and Turkish ice cream are popular. A live dosa counter, where chutney is stone-ground and served fresh, is also popular.”

Avant garde

Couples are willing to spend more on events such as the sangeet, mehendi and haldi than they would on the wedding ceremony, he adds.

While the buffet continues to feature at some weddings, caterers say the format is also being rethought, with greater emphasis on live counters,

Priyamedha Dutta

priyamedha.dutta@thehindu.co.in

Almost 400 years ago, in the small temple town of Nathdwara in Rajasthan, an art form emerged in which painters began covering cloth backdrops with images of Shrinathji – the seven-year-old form of Krishna worshipped there, characterised by almond-shaped eyes, a stocky build, and a sharp nose. These hangings, called *pichwais* (from *pichh*, meaning ‘behind’, and *wai*, meaning ‘hanging’), were draped behind the idol, changing with the seasons and festivals.

At Forum Art Gallery, artist Yugdeepak Soni brings that same tradition through his Sri Pichwai exhibit. The paintings are a part of the pichwai legacy rooted in the Pushtimarg tradition of 16th Century. Yugdeepak, who hails from Udaipur, has been associated with pichwai artworks for more than two decades now. He is



Colours of the past

Yugdeepak Soni brings the centuries-old pichwai tradition to Forum Art Gallery

the student of his *nanaji* (grandfather), Badri Lal Chitrakar from Bhilwara, Rajasthan.

“I was a good observer in my school days. My teachers and my uncle used to say that a good observer is more important than a good painter. Pichwai was in my

blood, so nobody had to push me into it. I felt like I needed to hold the brush too. I was privileged that my gurus were within my own house. With so many artists under one roof, it became easy for me to adopt their approach to art,” he says. Talking about the

Painting devotion (Left) Pichwai artworks titled Baramasa; (below) Vishwaroopam. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



tradition, Yugdeepak says, “In the Nathdwara temple, lord Krishna is revered as a seven-year-old child who was not permitted to step outside. To ensure the young deity could still experience and celebrate every auspicious occasion, artisans painted these backdrops to

bring the daily and seasonal festivals inside the temple.”

Traditionally painted on cotton cloth and now on handmade paper, most of these paintings chronicle the celebratory life of Shrinathji, focussing on key seasonal festivals like Janmashtami (his birth), Sharad Purnima (the autumn full moon *raas leela* dance), and Govardhan puja, narrating the mythological scene where Krishna lifted Mount Govardhan on his little finger to shield the villagers of Braj from the storms sent by lord Indra.

Like traditional pichwai paintings, Yugdeepak's works feature elaborate scenes, with the cow emerging as a recurring motif – a companion of Shrinathji. The lotus, peacock, and monsoon clouds also appear as symbols, allowing the artist to place himself in the presence of the traditional divine image.

The artist explains how colour plays an important role in these paintings and how and where, traditionally, most of these colours come

from. “Traditional artists use natural pigments and semi-precious stones. These pigments come in powder, semi-powder, or stone forms. For instance, a specific red is derived from a stone called *hinglu*, which must be crushed, ground and put through a purification process where only two grams of red colour are derived from 10 grams of stone,” he says.

When he is asked about the future of pichwai paintings, Yugdeepak does not seem very hopeful. “I don't think the coming generation will have that same level of patience, because everything they want is at their fingertips. They will encourage pichwai; they will buy the end product, but they won't encourage the process of traditional art. That's the difference,” he says.

Sri Pichwai is on till October 30, at Forum Art Gallery, Padmanabha Nagar, Adyar, from Monday to Saturday, from 10.30am to 6.30pm.



Coming home to Stella Maris

The Alumnae Association of Stella Maris College (AASMC) organises its Annual Alumnae Meet 2026.

More than just a gathering, the meet offers an opportunity to walk familiar corridors once again, reconnect with old friends and mentors, and share stories with fellow Stella Marians across batches and departments. For generations of Stella Marians, the Open Air Theatre (OAT) has been more than just a venue; it is a cherished landmark woven into shared memories. The AASMC is also raising funds towards the renovation of this treasured space, ensuring that it continues to host the milestones and memories of students for years to come.

The reunion is on October 10, 9am onwards followed by alumnae and department meets and lunch at Stella Maris College, Cathedral Road. Contact 28111987; email principal@stellamariscollege.edu.in; visit stellamariscollege.edu.in for details.

Bon appetit (Clockwise from below) National Durbar Restaurant; a view of Hotel Khaja; flaky parotta stuffed with mutton; and seeraga samba biryani. R RAVINDRAN AND SR RAGHUNATHAN



Nikhil Raghavan

Historically, Periamet, has long served as a gateway to the city for travellers, traders, and businessmen. Also known as Periyampet or Periyamedu, this is one of Chennai’s oldest neighbourhoods. The streets bustle with century-old lodges, mansions, hotels, restaurants, travel agencies, and countless tea stalls open at all hours of the day and night. Join us as we embark on a food trail in search of the neighbourhood’s best meals.

Breakfast of champions I get off the Central Metro and walk down the well-laid pedestrian pathway outside of the Greater Chennai Corporation’s nerve centre, the iconic white Ripon Building. At National Durbar Restaurant, founded in 1955, I ask the waiter for his favourite breakfast dish. He says, “There’s

The Periamet crawl

From National Durbar Restaurant to canteens feeding the migrant workforce, Periamet serves meals amid some of the city’s most iconic buildings

nothing to beat parotta-chicken curry. It will carry you through till lunch time.” The meal includes two medium-sized parottas and a quarter portion of chicken curry with two succulent pieces. Good for two, with tea, all for ₹192. National Durbar Restaurant is famously known for its special falooda, but I feel it is too much to indulge for breakfast.

Biryani on a budget I work up an appetite by walking around the area to take in the landmarks, and I suggest you do the same: Strolling is character-building. The area has

after all, housed some of the city’s most prized structures. The Victoria Public Hall adjacent to Ripon Building stands tall and stately in red brick. Central Station buzzes with activity. Further down the road is Anna City Armoury which sells guns and ammunition. I make my way to Hotel Khaja to meet the owner, P Rafeeq Ahmed. “Periamet has not been the same after the Covid period. Almost 80% of the leather businesses have closed. Many leather manufacturers and tanneries are now only running showrooms. The locality has now become a place for bachelors who stay in rented rooms. Fortunately, biryani has become a staple diet for many and in quite a few restaurants, the catering happens from lunch till late into the night.” Set up in 2000 on the Poonamalle High Road side of Periamet, Rafeeq sensed that opening another location closer to the Masjid and the Nehru Stadium made good business sense. “So, in 2004, we opened this location on Vepery High Road. Our speciality is Vaniyambadi biryani, besides several other dishes.” The ‘several other’ seems intriguing and I ask Rafeeq to surprise me with his favourite dish and what appears is a triangular piece of flaky parotta stuffed with mutton kheema – a meal by itself.

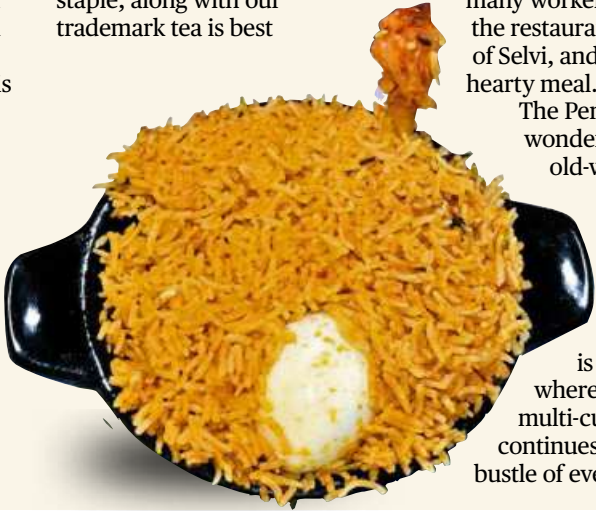
Bun-butter-Buhari I stroll down Vepery High Road, past the imposing, green-walled Periamet Masjid, past scores of

Name game Historian V Sriram, in his article published in *The Hindu* on May 29, 2015, wrote about a Pereira Street off Waltax Road near Central Station. Sriram informs me that a John Pereira did own lands nearby and the area was known as Jambura Thottam, colloquially referred to as Jamla Thottam. John Pereira was a Portuguese merchant who traded with the East India Company in the 1600s. It is possible that the name Periamet derived from Pereira, although there is no authenticity to that fact.

leather goods showrooms. Most of them sell shoes, bags, and other leather accessories, mostly made for exports. Along Raja Muthiah Road are snack outlets like Tantea Elite Cafe and Sri Krishna Vilas Tiffin Centre. Unable to resist, I walk into Buhari Hotel for its trademark mutton samosas and tea. I am disappointed to learn that due to the commercial cooking gas shortage, they have suspended making samosas. “Instead, our special bun-butter-jam, another Buhari staple, along with our trademark tea is best

recommended,” says the manager. The soft fluffy bun, specially made for Buharis, is split into halves and heavily layered with Amul butter. This is topped with a huge dollop of mixed fruit jam which again is specially made for Buharis. Wash this down with the tea and the process is complete.

A seeraga samba dinner The exhausted traveller has three exciting options for dinner – Selvi Mess’s seeraga samba mutton biryani, Hotel Khaja’s Vaniyambadi biryani or Periamet Nayeem Biryani’s Vaniyambadi chicken and mutton special biryani. When I come across Selvi Mess, prominently located on Poonamalle High Road, I meet R Manoj, the owner. “Selvi Mess has existed in Periamet since 1983. From an interior street, we have relocated to Poonamallee High Road in Periamet, to cater to a larger customer base. While we are open for breakfast, lunch and dinner, people come here for our speciality seeraga samba mutton biryani,” he says, adding that it is the short-grain rice from Tamil Nadu that gives the biryani its special flavour. Considering the affordable price point (starting from ₹160 for chicken and ₹250 for mutton), many workers in the area flock to the restaurants including the likes of Selvi, and H Akbar Mess for a hearty meal. The Periamet of today is a wonderful amalgamation of old-world charm, traditional cuisine and fast food. KFC and Murugan Idli Shop stand cheek by jowl with H Akbar Mess and Buhari Hotel. It is a neighbourhood where Chennai’s rich multi-cultural character continues to thrive amid the bustle of everyday life.



Matcha by the sea

Tucked inside Scor’d sports facility on Palavakkam beach, Brew’d serves up sea views, katsu sandos, and a standout matcha-jasmine drink

Sanjana Ganesh
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

In a treasure map, ‘X’ often marks the crudely covered spot where the bounty lies. On Palavakkam beach, one need not try to look for obscure ‘Xs’ to find treasure. The breeze, even during Chennai’s strangely searing September, is light and rewarding enough for those who choose to make the hike. Today, Palavakkam seems to have steadily become the preferred choice for a number of restaurants and cafes to begin their East Coast Road sojourn. Arun Bharadwaj says that it was about time that there was a spot in his neighbourhood where one could eat, play, and work too. It is why he and his school friend, Murali Ravikumar, founded Brew’d, a cafe inside the two-month old Scor’d, their sports facility with turfs and courts. Although the cafe is tucked among courts the facility itself is impossible to miss. On its wall, is a *paati* playing pickleball. “We [Murali and him] were ready to begin Brew’d and Scor’d



Worth it Try coffee and croissants at Brew’d. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

a year ago. We are two boys from Chennai who grew up by the beach. I am interested in hospitality and food, and Murali works with Adidas in Germany. With both our combined prowess, we wanted to create a third space where people could come through the day, play a game, work, workout, and mingle,” Arun says. Brew’d’s beverage and branding consultant Nishanth J and Chef Shyam Sundar say that they have been precise while coming up with this cafe menu. I sample their katsu chicken

sando which is a solid, and easy meal to eat, especially while working. I also enjoy drinking their signature drink When Matcha Met Malli. Made with ceremonial-grade cold-whisked matcha, jasmine tea, oat milk and wild honey, this drink disallows the jasmine notes to overpower the matcha. The two flavours with the oat milk as base, come together with no real effort. Their crisp shrooms, a small bowl of batter-fried oyster mushrooms, could use a thinner, more flavourful batter as the oyster mushrooms themselves come with a chewy meat-like flavour. There is an array of coffees, sharing plates, burgers, and all-day breakfast options to try at this 35-seater cafe but the stellar views of the sea and a genuine attempt at a calm, relaxed atmosphere, make Brew’d an option to add to your work-from-cafe list.

Brew’d is at 3, Baywatch, Karunanidhi Beach Road, Palavakkam. A meal for two costs around ₹1,500.



Hot and cold

Baked cheese cake or luscious hazelnut hot chocolate? Choose your pick as Moddy’s completes 75 years of serving chocolates in Udthagamandalam

K Jeshi
jeshi.jeshi@thehindu.co.in

Picture this: misty hills all around as a cup of hazelnut hot chocolate awaits. A perfect setting unfolds at Moddy’s confectionery and bakery in Udthagamandalam, Nilgiris, as it completes 75 years of serving chocolates. As I enjoy the velvety chocolate drink, baked cheesecake served with a drizzle of milk chocolate and triple chocolate hazelnut gateaux beckon. While the baked cheesecake is dense, creamy, chocolatey and almost melt-in-the-mouth, the triple chocolate one comes with layers of luscious chocolate. “Tourists visiting Ooty stop by for our hot chocolate,” says Muralidhar Rao, managing director, adding that the Moddy’s version is European in style: thick, creamy and chocolate-forward rather than dominated by milk. “We have as many as 10 varieties including classic, 70% extra dark, salted caramel, Mexican spice, pistachio, cookie and cream, and also an intense orange besides mixed berries. We also pair them with Ooty strawberries and blueberries to support farmers here.” Muralidhar is the owner of Modern Stores, started in 1951 by his father Janardhan Rao. What began as a modest confectionery section attached to Modern Stores gradually became Moddy’s. “Hostel kids back then used to shorten Modern Stores to Moddy’s and that’s how the name became our brand. Butlers who worked for the British shared their recipes with

us,” he says adding that the colonial legacy played a significant role in the popularity of chocolates among residents and tourists. As tourism grew, Moddy’s chocolates travelled far and wide. “My father used classic recipes using cocoa butters and no vegetable oils, a legacy we hold on to. What my father taught me was if the recipe has butter, it has to be butter and what you serve your kid is what you sell. We pick our cocoa directly from farmers across Mangaluru, Kerala and Andhra.”

A sweet legacy Muralidhar describes Moddy’s as a chocolate-based, large format confectionery and bakery where you can pick up ice creams, chocolates, beverages, and coffee. “I was literally born in a chocolate factory,” he says. The production unit was behind his house and he spent time with the butlers watching chocolates in the making. By the age of 14, he was making chocolates. Today, Moddy’s makes over 1,000 products, all eggless from the in-house kitchens, run entirely by women. There are more than 200 varieties of chocolate, around 25 varieties of fudge, and a bakery range that runs into hundreds of products, from croissants, Danishes and baguettes to sourdoughs, Korean buns, *varkeys* and rusks. “As

vegetarians, I remember our childhood. We couldn’t eat pastries and cakes because they always had eggs,” he says, adding, “I thought, why not make them without eggs?” He also experimented with the Japanese cake without eggs, traditionally made with egg whites. “Our R&D runs for 365 days. My approach has always been hands-on. I first learn and then train my team,” he says recalling his travels across Europe exploring chocolate traditions and his visits to Gelato University in Italy to study the craft. Among the chocolates, the classic roasted almond, in milk and dark chocolate variants, has been a top-seller for the past five decades while the hot chocolate has a cult following. “I have people travelling from Mysuru and Coimbatore just to have the hot chocolate. Our hazelnut gateaux served with milk chocolate, special ganache layered cake, chocolate ice cream, and Korean buns became a rage. From making 100 Korean buns a day we have touched 1,000 a day, with people queuing up. We make our fudge the traditional way where we melt the fudge in a marble slab to ensure quality. Everything counts.” Today, they make around 15 to 20 tonnes of chocolate a month, depending on the season. An outlet in Conoor came up in 2018 and more followed in Kotagiri, Wellington, Yercaud, Kodaikanal and Ulundurpet. All stores are spread across 2,000 to 4,500 sq ft, making them family-friendly rather than premium chocolate destinations. “We have addressed the challenge of transporting chocolate, bakery products and gelatos from a hill station through temperature-controlled storage and logistics.” Having served Governors, the current President of India, and several other personalities in films, and politics (Rahul Gandhi paid a visit to their factory during his Ooty visit in 2023), he describes quality and consistency as central to their chocolate-making tradition. “My idea is to showcase what a small town in Nilgiris can serve the country. Ooty has become a 365-day tourist destination. People love the rains, sunshine, mist, and cold. Those entering my store are already aware that I sell chocolates with 90% cocoa. My customers do my marketing,” he says, adding, “The only way to pay back their love is offering quality that is consistent.”



METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #72
(Set by Doppelganger)

Across

1 Unaccompanied (4)
3 Group of readers (4,4)
9 Charge (7)
10 Compound of oxygen (5)
11 Farewell (5)
12 Refrain in a song (6)
14 This or that (6)
16 Movable curtain (6)
19 Cashier (6)
21 Express (5)
24 Steel joist (1-4)
25 German police (7)
26 Sensory nerve (8)
27 Hereditary unit (4)

Down

1 Brine (8)
2 Small tropical fruit (5)
4 Used after number to denote time (6)
5 Industrial city in Japan (5)
6 Free time (7)
7 Raised (4)
8 Make certain (6)
13 Again (4,4)
15 Concerning that (7)
17 Dairy product (6)
18 Work shoe (6)
20 Arboreal primate (5)
22 Speak (5)
23 Isinglass (4)

Solution No. 72

To play The Guardian Quick Crossword, The Hindu Cryptic Crossword, Sudoku & other puzzles online, scan the QR code.



Sanjana Ganesh
sanjana.g@thehindu.co.in

In the two decades of reporting on Sri Lankan Tamil refugees in India, senior journalist RK Radhakrishnan has come to a pivotal realisation. “They do not want sympathy, they want to be seen,” he writes in his director’s statement for *Faceless People – The Journey of Sri Lankan Tamil Refugees in India*, his debut documentary on an oppressed community that he tracked long before picking up the camera to call ‘action’ and ‘cut’.

This documentary which has been selected as a finalist in the SHORTS! European Short Film Festival in Oslo (December 14) follows the lives of six refugees. Among them is a school boy, a housewife, a young woman with academic dreams, and the community’s first PhD scholar.

All of them barring two of the youngest, arrived on the Indian shore on boats, undergoing adverse, inhumane conditions, to escape the brutal killings of Sri Lankan Tamils in northern Sri Lanka.

Lights in the distance

Faceless People, a documentary, follows Sri Lankan Tamil refugees in India who remain in a legal limbo

Radhakrishnan, who donned the hat of a director after nearly four decades of being a print journalist, says that the project grew out of his years spent reporting at camps across Tamil Nadu, including those in Thanjavur, Mannar, and Tiruchi.

“My first visit to a camp was in 2006. That was when Tamil Nadu had a cholera outbreak in the camps. About nine groups of Ministers were set up by [late Chief Minister] Karunanidhi’s government to visit the camps and find out what people needed. That was the first time a full-scale investigation into camp conditions was carried out. I thought that if the affected people spoke for themselves.. it would carry more weight than me saying it on their behalf,” he says.

Although the film holds within its bones, deep and raw emotions, it instead turns to speak about the subjects and the status of their Indian citizenship. Radhakrishnan says that most people in camp who have lived in India for a greater part of their lives, are yet to get their

Although the film holds within its bones, deep and raw emotions, it instead turns to speak about the subjects and the status of their Indian citizenship



citizenship. The residents of these camps lack voting rights, job access, and legal protection from exploitation.

Radhakrishnan asks what moral right India has to deny them citizenship especially when nearly 98% of the 89,830 refugees live peacefully. “This is a solvable problem stalled only by the absence of political will in New Delhi,” he says. Much of it is inertia rather than being an actual security threat, he adds.

“As a director, it was tempting for me to focus on the immediate physical and emotional condition of the refugees. The texture of their hopelessness, the quiet but steady erosion of hope, and the palpable fatigue induced by the waiting. I had to instead stay focussed on the larger question of their uncertain legal status, which is the reason their lives remain in limbo,” he says. In some ways, *Faceless People* attempts to dismantle the link between the refugees and their perception of being ‘threats’, especially post the 1991 assassination of former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi. It is evident in the way the filmmaker centres his subjects, but most lucid

STEPOUT



audiences to savour Tamil theatre through a collection of experiences that celebrates the simple pleasure of stories shared on stage. @Babaji Vidyashram, Sholinganallur. On September 26, 4pm and 6.30pm. For tickets, call 9840684440.



The artist in the studio
Portrait of an Artist is a book by photographer and artist Rohit Chawla. In this illustrated lecture and conversation, Rohit will speak with Ranvir Shah about the making of the book and his encounters with some of India’s most iconic artists. Turning his camera towards artists at work and in moments of quiet reflection, Rohit captures the intimate worlds of their studios. Featuring interviews by curator and art historian Kishore Singh, the book is published by the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, New Delhi, and Mapin Publishing, and forms part of Rohit’s larger body of work documenting creative practitioners. @The Lab @Shanta, T Nagar. On September 26, 6.30pm onwards. To register, call 9940620268.

Bringing together brands from across India.

hand braided leather accessories

25 Years of Duchess Utsav

Fashion | Jewellery | Food | Home Décor | Accessories
Lifestyle | Organic Products & much more

Your favourite Shopping Festival is back!

25th & 26th
SEPTEMBER 2026

Savera Hotel
Chennai
10 AM - 8 PM

In the mood for noise

A debut album later, Chennai-based musician Sunflower Tape Machine is all set to perform at Music Matters in Singapore this October

Sangita Rajan
sangitarajan.pb@thehindu.co.in

An artiste’s debut album is often their most personal piece of work – a distillation of the years, influences, instincts and experiments that led them to finding their voice. For Chennai-based independent musician Aryaman Singh, the new album is personal for another reason: it is five years of making music without ever quite setting out to make an album.

“I didn’t start in 2021 thinking, ‘I’m going to make an album.’ All the songs I kept writing through the years just started making sense. At some point, I decided I wanted to stop releasing singles and put out an album. The narrative for my album at the time was: this is all the music I have, this is all the music I’ve made in the last few years, and I’m putting it in chronological order of it being made so you can see how I’ve evolved,” says Aryaman, who goes by Sunflower Tape Machine.

Spanning eight tracks, *I LIKE NOISE. MATTER OF FACT, I LOVE IT.* is an indie/alternative rock record threaded with shoegaze (a subgenre of indie and alternative rock), with noise serving as its unifying force. The album moves between the more familiar Sunflower Tape Machine sound and a newer, more exploratory alt-rock territory, with a three-minute instrumental interlude of pure noise at its centre.

“The order of tracks now on the album is what I think is the most cohesive order for you to



Sound action (Above) Sunflower Tape Machine during his performance at Lollapalooza India 2026; (inset) the musician. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

experience the album. That being said, listen to the album in its entirety,” says Aryaman. At around 25 minutes, it is a relatively compact listen.

For five years, Aryaman made the album largely on his own, writing, recording and mixing the songs at home. “My music is very melody first. Usually it’s full instrumental and then it’s choruses first and then the verses come after,” he says.

Like every other song he has made, the entire production happens in his room in Chennai. Even the drums on the album’s final two tracks were recorded there, with Nikhil Rajkumar, who plays live with Sunflower and with bands including Godless and Demonic Resurrection, coming in to play them.

“I’ve grown up being a huge film guy, and a lot of the films that I’ve watched are the reason for my vocabulary today and just being up to date with pop

culture. So, Chennai and its access to other art forms has influenced the art that I make,” says Aryaman. He also credits the city’s slower, close-knit way of life for shaping the experiences that eventually find their way into his music.

The album’s five-year gestation also meant Aryaman had to reckon with an earlier version of himself. The first song he wrote for the record, *I Saw You*, dates back to 2021. “I made it a point not to change too much because I felt like it was 2021 Sunflower’s story, and I don’t want to take that away from him,” he says.

Now, that journey is taking him beyond Chennai. Aryaman will perform a set at Music Matters in Singapore this October, one of Asia’s leading music industry events. For an album that began as a collection of songs written without a larger plan, it feels like another step in Sunflower Tape Machine’s evolution – this time, taking the noise a little further from home.

I LIKE NOISE. MATTER OF FACT, I LOVE IT. is now streaming on major music streaming platforms.

Biscuits

தூய்மை மந்திரம்

THE HINDU

PLAY THE DIGITAL NATIVE MADRAS TREASURE HUNT

AND STAND A CHANCE TO WIN PRIZES

PLAY NOW ON WHATSAPP

*T&Cs apply. For detailed T&Cs, scan the QR code for the Digital Hunt. Contest valid only in Tamil Nadu. AI generated content.

Man of many lives